

Remaking Color

This project examines how the color identity of the same story transforms across cinematic eras.

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Abstract

This thesis explores the evolution of cinematic color identity across historical periods. Using film remakes as a comparative framework, the research analyzes how identical narratives are chromatically reinterpreted over different decades to reflect changing aesthetic sensibilities. Remakes offer a unique opportunity to observe how the same narrative is visually reinterpreted in different decades, allowing aesthetic differences to be analyzed while the underlying story remains relatively constant.

By comparing films that share the same narrative but were produced in different historical contexts, the project investigates how color palettes and chromatic atmospheres evolve across cinematic eras. By integrating traditional film analysis with computational methods, the project translates cinematic data into comparative visualizations. Ultimately, this work reveals broader patterns in cinematic color usage and contributes to both film studies and data visualization by offering a novel, structured approach to examining aesthetic transformations within visual culture.

Acknowledgements

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Also, I would like to thank my family and friends for their constant encouragement and belief in me. This thesis would not have been possible without their unwavering support.

Finally, *“I wanna thank me for believing in me. I wanna thank me for doing all this hard work. I wanna thank me for having no days off. I wanna thank me for... for never quitting. I wanna thank me for just being me at all times”* — Snoop Dogg, (2018)

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Introduction

Color has long functioned as one of the most expressive elements of cinematic visual culture. Beyond decoration, color shapes atmosphere, communicates emotion, establishes genre expectations, and influences how audiences perceive narrative worlds. In cinema, movie posters often serve as the first visual encounter between a film and its audience, condensing the identity of a story into a single image through composition, typography, imagery, and chromatic design. The use of color within these promotional materials is therefore not incidental, but deeply connected to broader aesthetic, cultural, and technological tendencies of a given historical moment.

Throughout the history of cinema, chromatic aesthetics have continuously evolved alongside changes in film technology, graphic design trends, printing processes, and audience expectations. As cinematic styles shift across decades, the visual language of film posters also transforms. Certain historical periods favor highly saturated palettes, while others lean toward desaturation, monochromatic imagery, or digitally enhanced contrasts. These changes reflect not only advancements in media production, but also broader cultural attitudes toward realism, emotion, spectacle, and nostalgia. Paul Coates explores how color functions as a central aesthetic force within cinema, arguing that chromatic intensity shapes both visual meaning and audience experience. Similarly, Patti Bellantoni emphasizes the psychological and emotional power of color in visual storytelling, demonstrating how specific palettes become associated with narrative tone and affective response.

Given the central role of color in cinematic promotion and visual storytelling, this thesis asks: how do remake movie posters visually reinterpret the same narrative across different historical periods through changing chromatic aesthetics? As graphic design trends, printing technologies, and cinematic visual cultures evolve, the color palettes used to market films also shift accordingly. By examining remake posters produced across different decades, this research investigates how color functions as a historical marker of changing aesthetic tendencies while the narrative source material remains relatively constant.

Remakes provide a particularly effective framework for this analysis because they maintain recognizable story structures while adapting their visual identities to new

cultural and aesthetic contexts. While the story, characters, or core themes often remain relatively stable, the promotional imagery surrounding these films adapts to the visual conventions of its historical moment. This creates a controlled basis for comparison in which color becomes an observable variable through which broader aesthetic transformations can be identified. Comparing remake posters across decades therefore makes it possible to examine how cinematic marketing imagery reflects evolving visual trends while maintaining continuity with an existing narrative property.

This thesis argues that remake movie posters reveal broader historical transformations in cinematic visual aesthetics through their changing use of color. By isolating posters connected to the same narrative source material, the project creates a comparative framework through which shifts in chromatic language become more visible across decades. Combining film studies, color theory, and computational analysis, the research extracts dominant color palettes from remake posters and translates them into comparative visualizations that reveal patterns, repetitions, and aesthetic shifts across historical periods. Through this approach, the thesis proposes a method for examining how cinematic visual identities are reconstructed over time, revealing the evolving relationship between cinema and color culture.

Historical & Theoretical Context

2.1. Color Theory in Cinema

Color has played a fundamental role in the development of cinematic visual language since the earliest decades of film history. Although early cinema was initially limited to black-and-white imagery, filmmakers and studios quickly recognized the expressive and commercial potential of color. Hand painted film strips, tinting techniques, and later technological innovations such as Technicolor transformed color into an essential component of cinematic storytelling. Over time, color evolved from a technological novelty into a sophisticated narrative and emotional device capable of shaping audience perception, atmosphere, and symbolic meaning.

Within film theory, color is often understood as both a perceptual and cultural phenomenon. Rainer Mausfeld and Dieter Heyer describe color perception as a process that exists between physical stimuli and psychological interpretation, emphasizing that color is never experienced as purely objective information. Instead, color perception is shaped by biological, cognitive, and contextual factors that influence how viewers interpret visual environments. In cinema, this relationship becomes particularly significant because filmmakers intentionally manipulate color to direct emotional responses and construct visual meaning.

The expressive potential of color in film has been explored extensively by scholars and practitioners. Patti Bellantoni argues that color functions as a psychological language capable of communicating emotional states before narrative information is consciously processed by the viewer. Certain chromatic associations become culturally recognizable over time: red may suggest danger, passion, or violence, while blue often evokes melancholy, distance, or calmness. These associations are not universal or fixed, but they demonstrate how color operates as a communicative system within visual storytelling. Rather than functioning as decoration, color becomes an active narrative force capable of shaping mood, tension, and audience expectation.

Similarly, Paul Coates emphasizes the relationship between color and cinematic aesthetics, arguing that saturation, contrast, and chromatic intensity contribute

significantly to the sensory experience of film. According to Coates, color does not simply accompany narrative content but actively structures how cinematic worlds are perceived. The “saturated image” becomes a defining characteristic of modern cinema, reflecting changing aesthetic sensibilities as well as technological developments in film production and exhibition.

In promotional materials such as movie posters, these chromatic strategies become condensed into a single image. Posters must communicate genre, atmosphere, emotional tone, and audience expectations almost instantaneously. Through color, posters create visual identities that frame how a film is perceived before it is even watched. Horror films frequently rely on dark contrasts and limited palettes, romantic dramas often emphasize warm tones, and action films commonly employ highly saturated complementary colors to intensify spectacle and energy. These visual conventions evolve historically, reflecting broader trends in graphic design, advertising, and cinematic culture.

Because movie posters operate at the intersection of cinema, graphic design, and marketing, they provide valuable material for examining how color functions culturally and aesthetically. The chromatic language of posters does not merely represent individual films, but also reflects the visual tendencies and technological capabilities of the period in which they were produced. As a result, the study of color in movie posters offers insight into broader transformations in cinematic aesthetics and visual communication across historical periods.

2.2. Evolution of Cinematic Aesthetics

Cinematic aesthetics have continuously transformed throughout the history of film, shaped by cultural movements, technological innovation, industrial practices, and changing audience expectations. These transformations affect not only cinematography and production design, but also the visual language of film promotion. Movie posters reflect the aesthetic priorities of their historical moment, functioning as visual artifacts that reveal how cinema presents itself to audiences across different decades.

Posters from the 1930s through the 1950s frequently relied on vivid, idealized imagery that reflected the spectacle associated with studio-era filmmaking.



Here Comes Mr. Jordan, 1941



Love Is News, 1937



Unfaithfully Yours, 1948

Saturated reds, yellows, red and blues were commonly used to attract attention and communicate emotional intensity. As color printing technologies improved, posters became increasingly visually elaborate, mirroring the growing importance of color cinema itself.

By the 1960s and 1970s, cinematic aesthetics began shifting alongside broader cultural and artistic transformations. Influenced by modernist graphic design, countercultural movements, and experimental filmmaking, posters adopted more abstract compositions, photographic imagery, and unconventional color palettes.

Carrie, 1976



Willy Wonka, 1971



Psycho, 1960



This period saw a growing interest in realism, psychological ambiguity, and visual fragmentation, trends that were reflected in promotional design. Rather than presenting polished idealization, many posters embraced darker tones, muted palettes, and more conceptual visual strategies.

The transition into the digital era during the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries introduced further aesthetic changes. Advances in digital photography, image editing software, and color grading technologies transformed both filmmaking and poster production. Contemporary movie posters frequently rely on digitally enhanced contrast, monochromatic color schemes, atmospheric lighting, and highly stylized compositions. Orange-and-blue complementary palettes became especially dominant in blockbuster marketing due to their visual intensity and readability across digital platforms. These aesthetic tendencies reflect not only technological capabilities but also the increasing globalization and standardization of cinematic marketing.

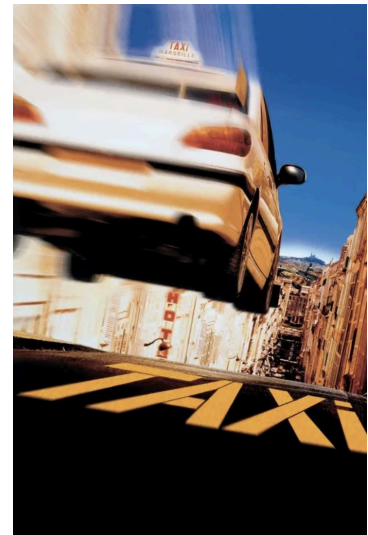
The Mummy, 1999



Point Break, 1991



Taxi, 1998



At the same time, nostalgia has become a recurring visual strategy within contemporary cinema. Many remakes intentionally reference earlier aesthetic styles while simultaneously adapting them to current visual conventions. This creates a tension between continuity and reinvention in which posters must evoke familiarity

while appearing visually contemporary. As a result, remake posters provide particularly valuable material for examining how cinematic aesthetics evolve over time.

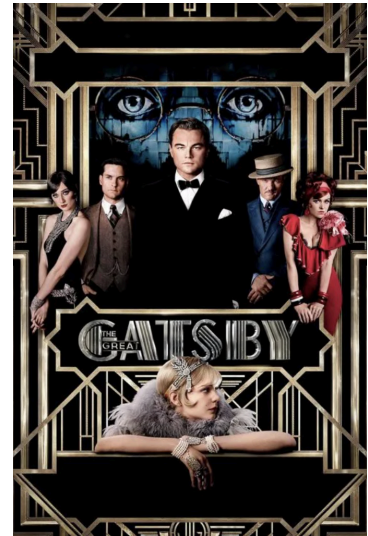
The Great Gatsby, 1974



The Great Gatsby, 2000



The Great Gatsby, 2013



The evolution of cinematic aesthetics is therefore not linear, but shaped by overlapping cultural, technological, and commercial influences. Movie posters capture these transformations visually, revealing how different historical periods construct cinematic identity through changing chromatic and graphic strategies. By comparing remake posters across decades, it becomes possible to observe how aesthetic values shift while narrative continuity remains relatively stable.

2.3. Technological Shifts in Color Grading and Film

The history of cinematic color is inseparable from the technological evolution of film production and image reproduction. Advances in film stock, printing methods, digital editing, and color grading technologies have fundamentally shaped how color appears within both films and their promotional materials. These technological shifts influence not only aesthetic possibilities but also the visual expectations audiences develop across different historical periods.

Early color processes in cinema were labor intensive and limited in accuracy. Techniques such as hand coloring, tinting, and toning introduced color artificially

into black and white film, often assigning emotional or atmospheric meaning to specific scenes. With the introduction of Technicolor in the 1930s, color became more vivid and commercially viable, producing highly saturated imagery associated with spectacle and fantasy. Developed through a series of experimental color processes by the Technicolor Motion Picture Corporation, the technology transformed Hollywood's relationship with chromatic imagery by enabling a level of saturation and visual intensity that had previously been impossible. The three strip Technicolor process, popularized in films such as *The Wizard of Oz* and *Gone with the Wind*, established color as a defining element of cinematic spectacle and significantly influenced the visual aesthetics of both films and their promotional materials.¹

As photographic and printing technologies improved during the mid twentieth century, movie posters gained greater chromatic precision and reproducibility. Offset printing allowed for more detailed color gradients and photographic realism, gradually replacing hand painted illustrations with photographic compositions. These changes altered the relationship between cinema and its promotional imagery, making posters increasingly dependent on photographic representation and color accuracy.

Technological developments therefore shape not only how color is produced, but also how cinematic identity is visually constructed and marketed. The chromatic differences visible between remake posters from different decades are not simply artistic choices; they are also products of changing technological infrastructures that influence what kinds of images can be created, reproduced, and circulated.

2.4. Remakes and Reinterpretation

Remakes occupy a distinctive position within film history because they combine narrative continuity with aesthetic transformation. Unlike entirely original works, remakes revisit preexisting stories, characters, or concepts while adapting them to new cultural, technological, and industrial contexts. This process of reinterpretation makes remakes especially valuable for comparative analysis, as they allow similarities and differences between historical periods to become more visible.

¹ Higgins, 2007

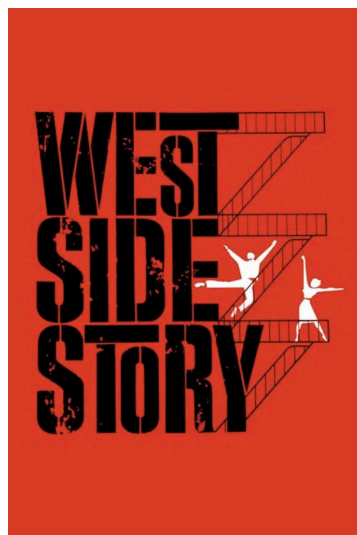
The relationship between remakes and historical context is closely tied to audience expectations. Each remake must negotiate between familiarity and novelty: it must remain recognizable enough to evoke the original while also appearing visually relevant to the new viewers. Promotional materials play a central role in this negotiation. Movie posters communicate how a remake positions itself in relation to its source material, visually signaling whether the film emphasizes nostalgia, modernization, realism, spectacle, or reinterpretation. This makes it possible to isolate chromatic transformation as a key variable within the comparative analysis.

Remakes also reveal how cinematic industries reinterpret cultural memory visually. Posters often preserve recognizable iconography from earlier versions while updating composition, typography, lighting, or color palettes to reflect contemporary aesthetics.

The study of remakes therefore provides insight into how visual culture reconstructs familiar narratives for new audiences. Through their promotional imagery, remakes become records of changing aesthetic values, demonstrating how historical periods reinterpret cinematic identity through evolving chromatic and graphic languages.

West Side Story Case

In the case of West Side Story (the 1961 original and the 2021 remake), a clear comparison can be made. The original features a solid color with the iconic fire escape symbol and 'cracked' typography. In contrast, the 2021 remake uses a photograph of the film's characters, while still incorporating the fire escape symbolism and the same typographic style. The poster changed, but its symbols and essence did not. This serves to connect the original audience with the new version.



2.5 Emotional and Narrative Role of Color

Color functions not only as an aesthetic element, but also as a powerful emotional and narrative tool within visual culture. In cinema and film promotion, color influences how audiences interpret atmosphere, anticipate genre, and emotionally engage with imagery. Before viewers encounter a film itself, movie posters already establish expectations through their chromatic composition, shaping emotional perception through color associations and visual tone.

Patti Bellantoni describes color as a form of emotional shorthand capable of triggering psychological responses rapidly and often subconsciously. Warm tones such as red, orange, and yellow are frequently associated with intensity, passion, danger, or energy, while cooler tones such as blue and green often evoke isolation, calmness, or melancholy. These associations allow filmmakers and designers to communicate narrative tone visually before explicit story elements are introduced.

Color also contributes to genre recognition. Horror posters frequently employ dark palettes, desaturated imagery, and strong contrast to communicate tension and fear. Romantic films often rely on softer warm tones that suggest intimacy and emotional connection. Science fiction and action films commonly emphasize high contrast and saturated complementary palettes to convey spectacle, futurism, or technological intensity. These conventions become culturally recognizable over time, shaping audience expectations through repeated visual patterns.

Importantly, the emotional meaning of color is historically variable rather than universal. Cultural context influences how colors are interpreted and how chromatic styles become associated with particular moods or aesthetic values. As cinematic aesthetics evolve, the emotional strategies attached to color also shift. A highly saturated palette that once communicated fantasy or optimism may later appear artificial or nostalgic depending on its historical context.

Within remake posters, these emotional transformations become especially visible. A remake may reinterpret the same narrative as darker, more realistic, more nostalgic, or more spectacular simply through alterations in chromatic atmosphere. By comparing the dominant palettes of remake posters across decades, it becomes

possible to observe how emotional and narrative meanings are reconstructed visually over time.

Ultimately, color operates as both a perceptual and cultural system through which cinema communicates emotion, identity, and historical sensibility. The study of chromatic aesthetics in remake posters therefore reveals not only shifts in graphic design and marketing strategies, but also broader transformations in how cinema constructs emotional experience visually.

Methodology

3.1. Remake Selection

The dataset of remakes was curated using the Wikipedia Remakes Database. This process involved filtering film entries to identify pairs of "Original" and "Remake" movies. A critical step in the selection criteria was the exclusion of TV shows and television series; any family of remakes that transitioned into or originated from a broadcast show format was removed from the sample. Consequently, this study focuses strictly on feature films, ensuring a consistent medium for comparing visual languages and poster design conventions across different eras.

3.2. Poster Dataset

For each film identified in the previous step, high resolution posters were retrieved using The Movie Database (TMDb) API. The API allowed for the systematic collection of metadata (such as release year, genre, and country) alongside the poster images. To ensure the highest data quality, a final filtering process was conducted: any film not found in the TMDb database was removed from the dataset, along with its corresponding remake pair. This step was crucial to avoid missing information, as the poster is the primary object of this analysis. Following all filtering criteria, the final database consisted of 1,025 movies, representing 488 remake families.

3.3. Color Extraction Process

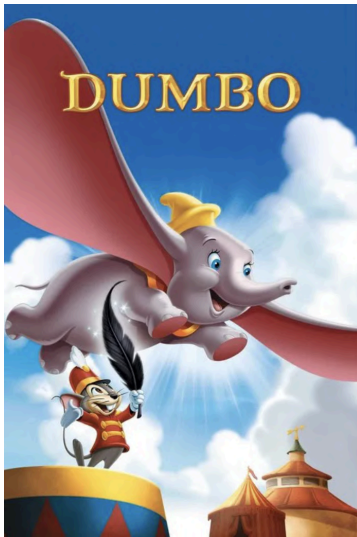
The color extraction workflow was designed to transform visual poster art into structured chromatic data through a systematic pipeline. The process follows a hierarchical reduction of data, moving from the full image to a single representative tone in four distinct stages:

3.3.1. Grid-Based Feature Extraction

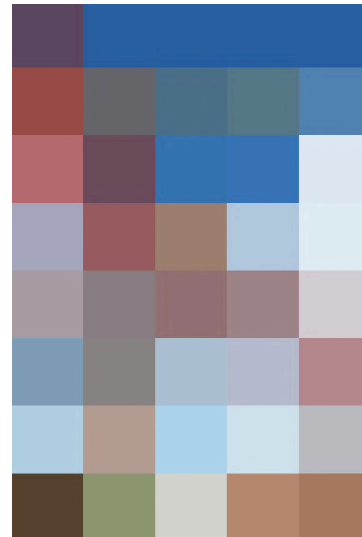
The primary stage of the analysis involves the systematic processing of the posters. Instead of analyzing the image as a single uniform block, each poster is divided into an 8×5 grid (40 cells in total).

- The Process: For each individual cell in the grid, a K-Means clustering algorithm (set to $n=1$) is applied to identify the most representative color (centroid) of that specific sector.
- Rationale: This results in a spatial color map where each movie is represented by a matrix of 40 RGB values. This method preserves the vertical and horizontal distribution of colors, allowing the analysis to distinguish, for example, between the color of a title at the bottom and the background or sky at the top.

Dumbo, 1941



Dumbo (8x5 grid), 1941

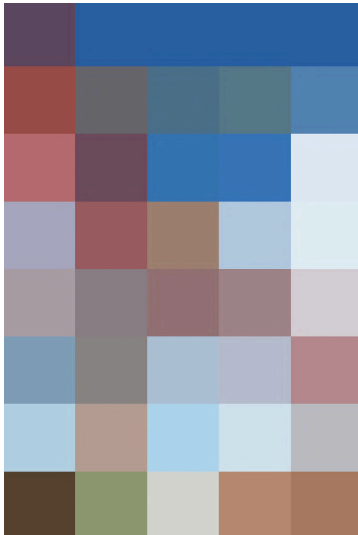


3.3.2. Color Synthesis

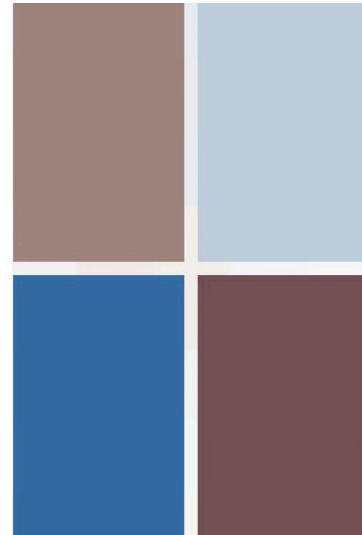
The 40 colors from the grid are then processed to create a reduced 4-color palette.

- The Process: A second K-Means clustering is applied to the 40 previously extracted centroids, this time with $n=4$.
- Rationale: This step simplifies the chromatic complexity of the poster into its essential components. It identifies the four most significant color groups, filtering out minor variations while retaining the core visual identity of the film's marketing.

Dumbo (8x5 grid), 1941



Dumbo (4 colors), 1941

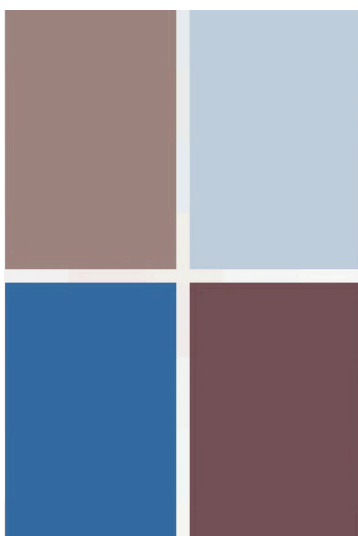


3.3.3. Dominant Color Selection

The final stage of the hierarchy reduces the data to a single "Dominant Color" using two complementary approaches:

- Perceptual Weighting (Local Color): A weighted average is calculated by converting the values to the HLS (Hue, Lightness, Saturation) color space. This method prioritizes high-saturation tones and penalizes grays or extreme highlights/shadows, capturing the "chromatic essence" that a human eye would most likely perceive as the main color.
- Mathematical Centroid: A final K-Means (n=1) calculation is applied to find the absolute statistical center of the poster's color distribution.

Dumbo (8x5 grid), 1941



Dumbo (dominant color), 1941



3.3.4. Data Consolidation and Validation

To ensure integrity, the system aggregates all hierarchical levels into a unified dataset. This includes verifying file signatures to ensure that only uncorrupted images are processed and standardizing all values into the RGB color space to ensure that comparisons between different eras and genres are mathematically sound.

3.4. Dominant Palette Analysis

Once the hierarchical color extraction is complete, the data is subjected to a Dominant Palette Analysis to identify trends across the dataset. This stage moves beyond individual images to understand the relationship between original films and their remakes.

3.4.1. Chromatic Distribution

By analyzing the 4-color palettes and the final dominant tone, the research quantifies the "color distance" between versions. This is achieved by comparing the distribution of hues and the shifts in brightness.

3.4.2. Historical Trends

The palettes are aggregated by decade and genre, enabling the identification of broader industry shifts, such as the evolution from high-contrast primary colors in early cinema posters to the more standardized "darker" or monochromatic palettes of modern digital marketing.

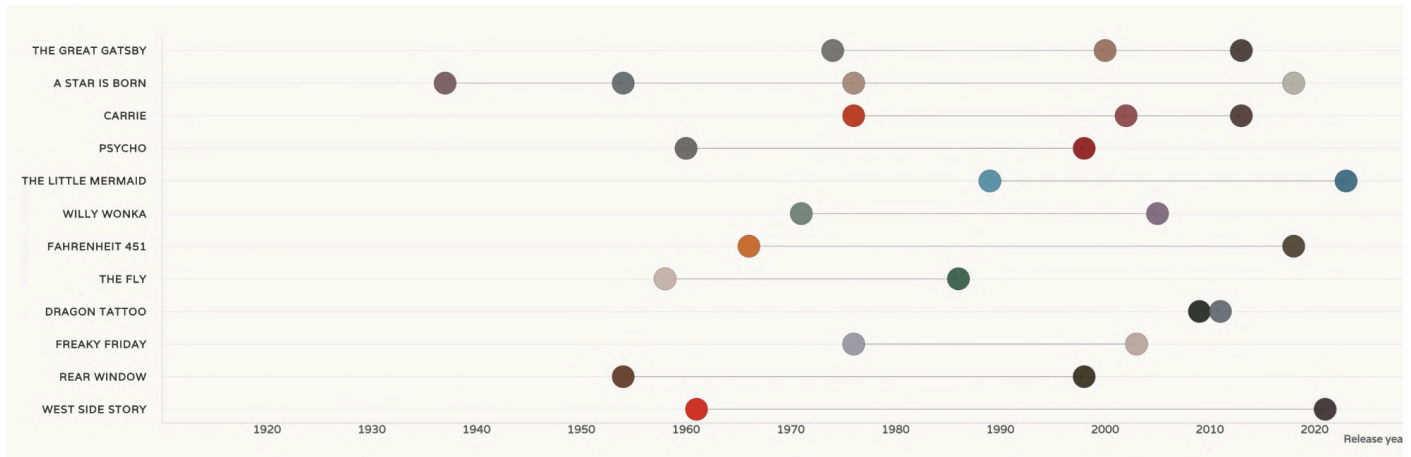
3.5. Visualization Methods

To interpret the high dimensional color data, a series of visualization techniques were developed. These methods are designed to make abstract numerical data (RGB/HLS values) intuitively understandable and most importantly, visually comparable.

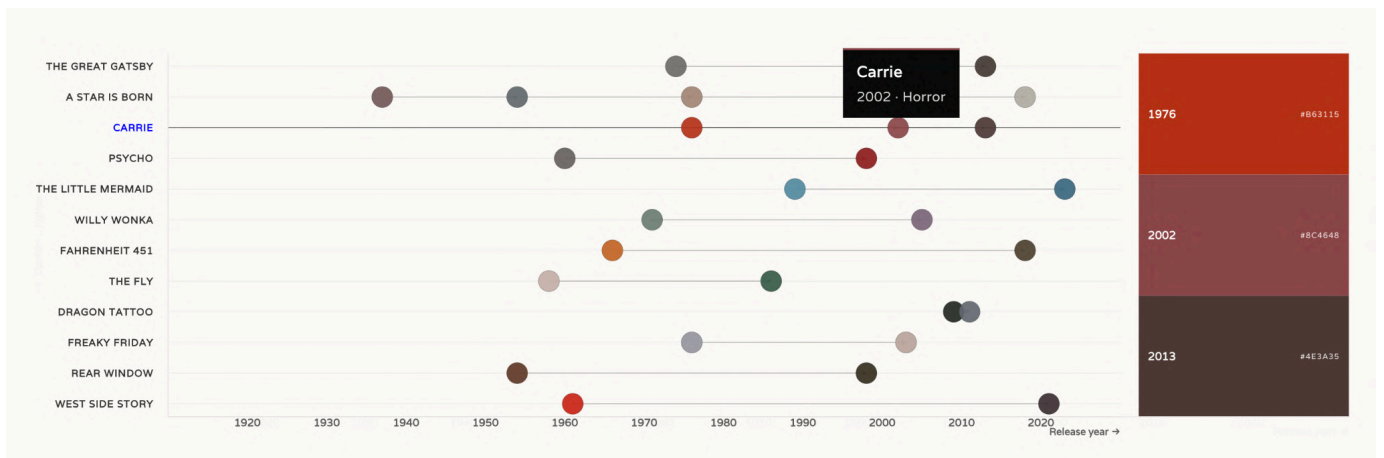
3.5.1. First Comparison

This interactive timeline visualizes the release history of various movie remakes over the decades. Each horizontal line (x-axis) represents a specific

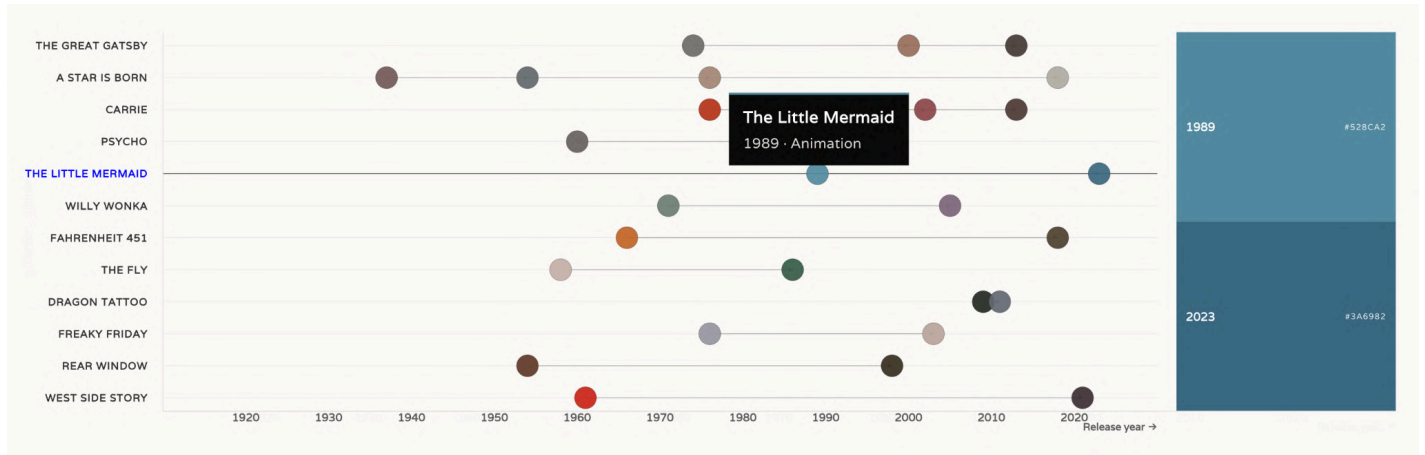
film title, with colored dots marking the release years (y-axis) of its different versions. When a movie is selected, the chart highlights its adaptations and displays a corresponding color palette on the right, illustrating the evolution of the film's visual aesthetic across time. This graph shows only the comparison of 12 (some of the most famous remakes) remake families from the database.



Here is an example with the comparison of *Carrie* can be seen. The three films all use a variation of red, but the color gradually becomes darker over time.

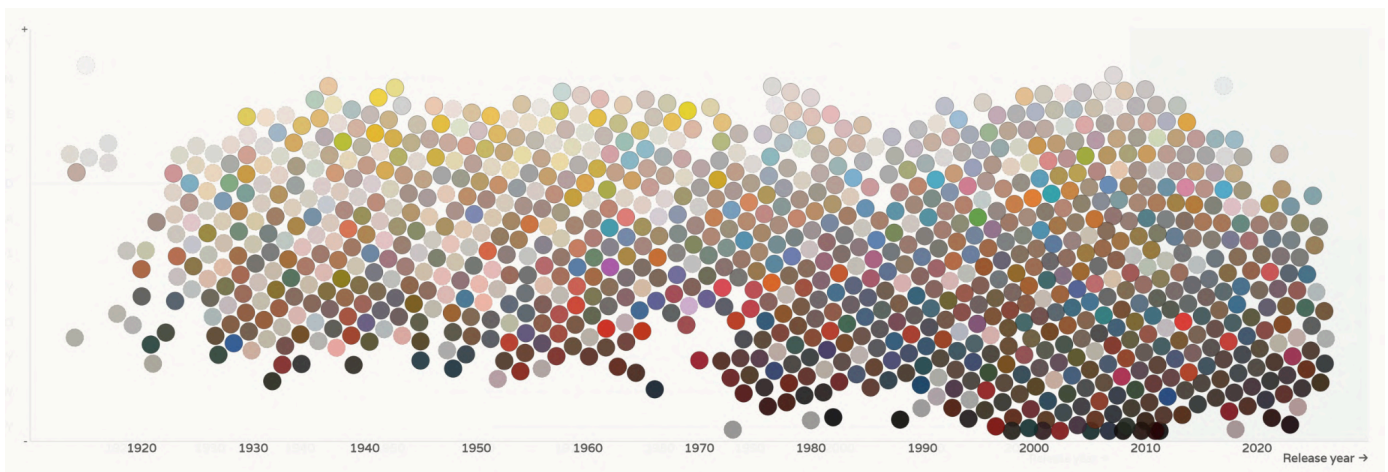


Another interesting example is *The Little Mermaid*; the original is an animated film, while the remake is live-action. Even though they tell the same story, and both are children's movies, we can see how the colors have become darker over time.



3.5.2. Bubble Chart - Color Over Time

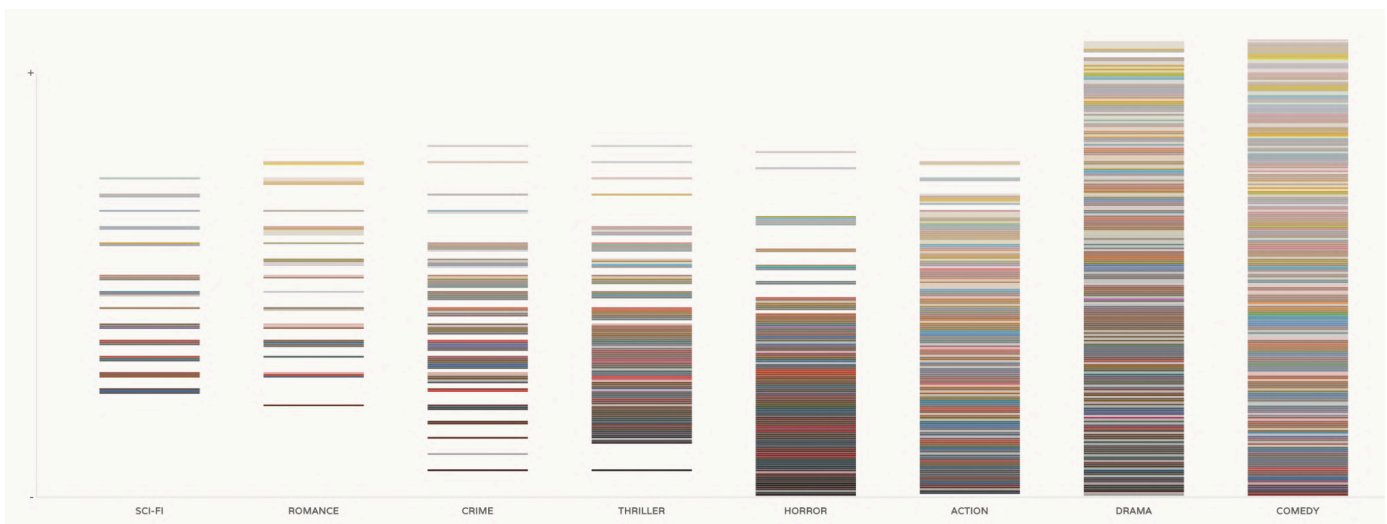
This chart represents a massive collection of films organized by their release year along the x-axis, spanning from approximately 1920 to the present day, and the brightness level in the y-axis. Each individual circle represents a movie, with its color reflecting the dominant color palette or visual tone of that specific film.



- Color Evolution: There is a visible trend where the top of the chart features lighter, more vibrant colors (yellows, pastels, and whites), while the bottom is dominated by darker, desaturated tones (deep reds, browns, and blacks).
- Density: The concentration of circles increases significantly moving toward the right (the 2000s and 2010s), illustrating the exponential growth in film production over the last few decades.
- Visual Narrative: Collectively, the chart acts as a "chromatic history" of cinema, suggesting that modern films have trended toward a darker or more "moody" aesthetic compared to the brighter palettes of mid-century cinema. There is a clear, downward trend. Even when telling the exact same stories, modern posters are objectively 'moodier' and darker than their mid-century ancestors.

3.5.3. Stacked Bar Chart - Color by Genre

This chart categorizes films by genre along the x-axis. Rather than using solid colors, each bar is composed of numerous thin horizontal lines, where each line represents an individual movie's dominant color. This creates a distinct chromatic signature for every genre, suggesting that these color palettes are intentional stylistic choices rather than accidental.



→ Visual Volume: The height of each bar effectively represents the volume of data available for each genre, highlighting that Drama and Comedy are the most popular categories in movie remakes.

- ◆ Horror and Thriller: These columns show a heavy concentration of dark lines at the base, reflecting the "moody" and low light aesthetic.
- ◆ Drama and Comedy: These are the tallest columns, indicating a much larger sample size. They also show a more even distribution of colors, stretching higher into the "lighter" spectrum.
- ◆ Sci-Fi and Romance: These show fewer remakes, shorter bars with more distinct spacing between the visual tones.

3.5.4. Comparative Gallery - The Atlas of Remakes



This graphic is a detailed comparative gallery that showcases the visual evolution between original films and their remakes. The left block represents the dominant color of the original poster, and the right block represents the dominant color of the remake's poster. The specific years of release are listed below each color swatch to provide chronological context.

- You can often spot a shift in "color temperature" or brightness between the remakes. For example, in titles like *Cape Fear* or *Clash of the Titans*, there is a noticeable move toward more high-contrast or modern digital palettes in the remakes.
- Some families maintain a very similar color story (like *Dumbo* or *Carrie*), while others undergo a complete visual overhaul to appeal to a new generation of audiences.

These visualization techniques transition from purely descriptive representation to analytical tools, enabling the identification of macro-patterns, such as the gradual 'darkening' of modern aesthetics, that remain obscured when examining images in isolation or through raw numerical data.

Results and Findings

In this section, I analyze the most important findings. By looking at the color data side by side, it becomes clear that the way movies are presented to us through their posters has changed drastically over the decades. These changes aren't just random artistic choices; they reflect how technology has evolved and how our own visual tastes as an audience have shifted.

By utilizing remakes as a comparative framework, the study isolates narrative variables to reveal systemic transformations in the visual language of cinema. The results demonstrate that the evolution of color is not merely aesthetic but reflects a deeper change in how chromatic atmospheres are constructed to communicate narrative and emotional tones across different eras.

4.1. The Shift Toward Desaturation and "Darker" Palettes

The most consistent pattern across the entire dataset is a significant drop in brightness. The data shows a trend where modern remakes move away from the high saturation, primary color palettes of the mid 20th century.

When we compare original films from the 60s, 70s, or 80s with their modern remakes, the data shows a clear move toward darker and more complex palettes. For example, in cases like *Fahrenheit 451* or *The Fly*, the original posters used light and vibrant backgrounds to catch the eye. In contrast, the modern versions rely heavily on deep shadows and low-light environments.

Fahrenheit 451, 1966



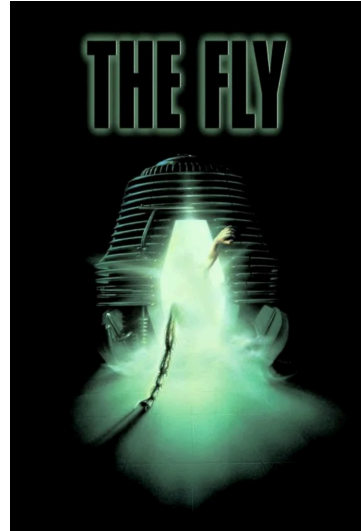
Fahrenheit 451, 2018



The Fly, 1958



The Fly, 1986



While early posters relied on offset printing and vivid Technicolor-inspired aesthetics, contemporary versions utilize digital color grading to create "moodier" and more atmospheric visual worlds.

This suggests that modern cinema is less interested in showing every detail and more focused on creating an "atmosphere." Today's posters often prioritize a specific mood, over the clear, high energy colors that were common in the past.

4.2. From Primary Colors to Digital Standardization

Another discovery is how the variety of colors has changed. Older posters tended to be more experimental, often using a wide range of primary colors like bright reds, blues, and yellows to tell a story.

The Michigan Kid, 1928



Little Miss Marker, 1934



Mystery of the 13th Guest, 1943



The Buccaneer, 1958

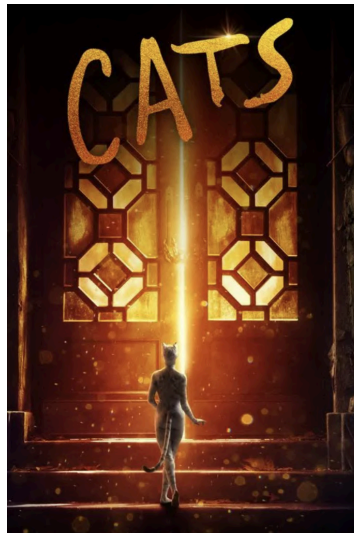


However, as we move into the era of digital marketing, we see a kind of "chromatic migration" where many films start to look darker.

Cinderella, 2015



Cats, 2019



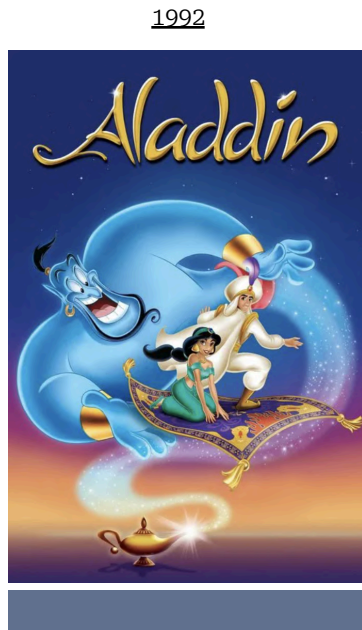
Lady and the Tramp, 2019



The data shows a clear trend toward darker, higher-contrast looks in modern remakes. This has become the industry standard mainly because these posters need to grab our attention instantly on small digital screens and mobile devices. While this style is great for advertising, it often comes at a cost: the unique 'color soul' of the original stories gets lost, replaced by a polished, digital formula that is designed more for commercial success than for artistic personality.

4.3. Narrative Loyalty vs. Visual Overhauls

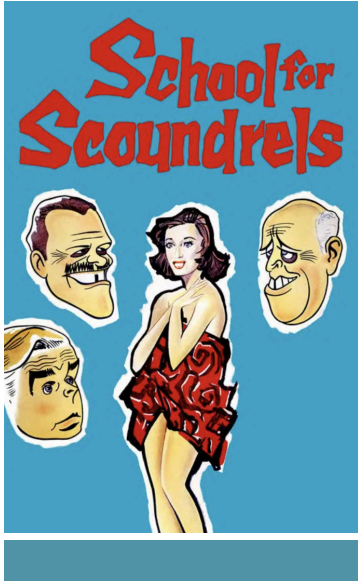
The comparative framework highlights how remakes negotiate between nostalgia and modernization. Finally it's interesting to see which movies decided to stay loyal to their roots and which ones changed completely. Some "families" of remakes, like *Aladdin*, made an effort to keep a similar color story, perhaps to maintain a connection with the nostalgia of the original audience. In these cases, the colors feel like an update rather than a replacement.



On the other hand, many films undergo a total visual overhaul. In these instances, the remake uses color to tell the audience that this is a "new" and "different" version of the story they already know. By changing a vibrant, colorful original into a monochromatic or desaturated remake, studios are signaling a change in tone, moving from the theatrical and stylized feel of early cinema to the gritty, cinematic style that defines movies today.

A clear illustration of this shift can be seen in *School for Scoundrels*. While the original version relies on a diverse and vibrant palette, the remake moves toward a much more restrained and monochromatic look, perfectly capturing this modern preference for a darker, more grounded visual tone.

1960



2006



These comparisons show that color acts as a bridge between the past and the present. Whether a remake chooses to honor the original palette or completely reinvent it, the choice is never accidental. It reveals a tension between preserving the nostalgic identity of a classic story and adapting it to the visual expectations of today's viewers. By analyzing these shifts, we can see that the 'chromatic soul' of a film is constantly evolving, reflecting a broader movement in cinema where the vivid, hand-painted feel of the past is being replaced by the sophisticated, atmospheric, and often darker tones of the digital age.

4.4 The Role of Genre in Color Evolution

Beyond historical shifts, the data shows that film genre plays a huge role in how color is used. Each genre has its own "visual DNA," but even these established rules have evolved as remakes try to modernize classic stories.

Genres like Horror and Thrillers are the most consistent when it comes to color. Whether it's an original from the 70s or a remake from 2020, these films almost always stay within a "dark" territory. The focus remains on shadows, cold blues, and deep reds to create a sense of fear. However, the difference lies in the *intensity*; modern horror remakes often use a much more desaturated, almost monochromatic look to make the story feel more "realistic" and less theatrical than the originals.

We can see this clearly in the Nosferatu family. The original posters used different colors to create a sense of mystery, but the modern remake moves away from that. Instead, it uses 'muddy' browns and greys to make the movie feel more realistic and gritty, which is exactly how most horror movies look today.



On the other hand, genres like Animation and Fantasy show a different kind of change. While older versions often used a soft, painterly palette, modern remakes, especially live-action ones, tend to push the contrast to the limit. They use digital tools to make colors glow and pop in a way that wasn't possible before. This creates a "hyper-real" look that feels more like a video game or a high-end digital production, moving away from the traditional "storybook" feel of the past.

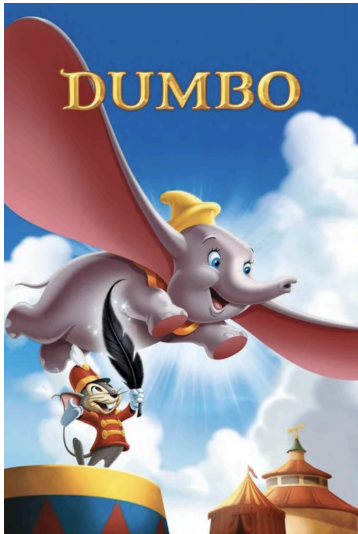
Bedazzled, 1967



Bedazzled, 2000



Dumbo, 1941

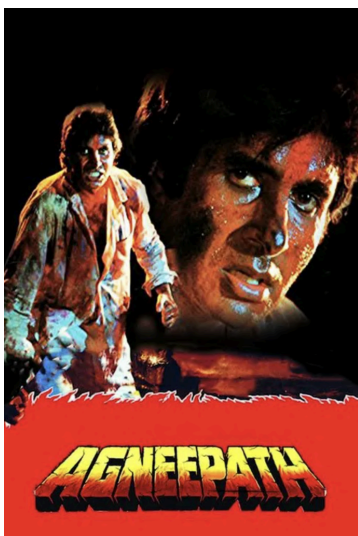


Dumbo, 2019



Action movies show the strongest migration toward the "teal and orange" trend. While older action posters were often more colorful and varied, modern remakes in this genre have narrowed their color choices significantly. They prioritize high-energy, high-contrast combinations that signal "excitement" and "modernity" to the audience, showing how commercial genres are the quickest to adopt new digital standards.

Agneepath, 1990



Agneepath, 2012



Gone in 60 Seconds. 1974



Gone in 60 Seconds. 2000



This suggests that while a genre like horror or action gives a film its basic color rules, the time period in which it is made is what really decides how those colors look. A remake doesn't just repeat the style of the original; it updates it to fit what audiences expect to see today. This means that as our visual culture changes, the genres themselves begin to look different. A remake is more than just a new version of a story; it is a visual transformation that translates an old into a modern language.

Conclusion

The creation of 'Remaking Color' has allowed me to look at movie history through a purely visual lens. Throughout this process, I've learned that color is much more than just a design choice to make a poster look pretty; it is actually a historical record of how we tell and see stories. By building a system that breaks down complex posters into measurable data, starting with a detailed 40-cell grid and simplifying it down to just one dominant color, I have been able to prove that our "feelings" about modern movies are real. We often feel that new movies are darker or less colorful, and now we have the numbers to back that up.

It is interesting to see that even though we now have more technological power than ever to create any color we can imagine, we have actually moved in the opposite direction. Instead of using more variety, we have narrowed our choices down to a specific set of digital palettes that we see over and over again. This research shows a strange paradox: as our tools got better, our visual world in cinema became more standardized. My goal with this project was to turn those subtle changes into something we can clearly see and compare, helping us understand how the "look" of our favorite stories continues to change as time goes by.

Ultimately, Remaking Color shows us that a remake is never just a copy; it is a translation. By looking at how these "Remake Families" change their skin over 90 years, we see that while our legends remain eternal, the way we perceive them is constantly being re-colored to match the world we live in.

Looking ahead, I see this project as just the beginning of a larger conversation about visual storytelling. While this thesis focused on posters because they are the "face" of a film, the same methodology could be applied to entire movies or even different types of media. There is still so much to explore regarding how different cultures or genres adapt these colors. My hope is that this work serves as a tool for both designers and film historians to understand that even when a story is remade, the colors tell a completely new version of that tale, reflecting the world we live in today.

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